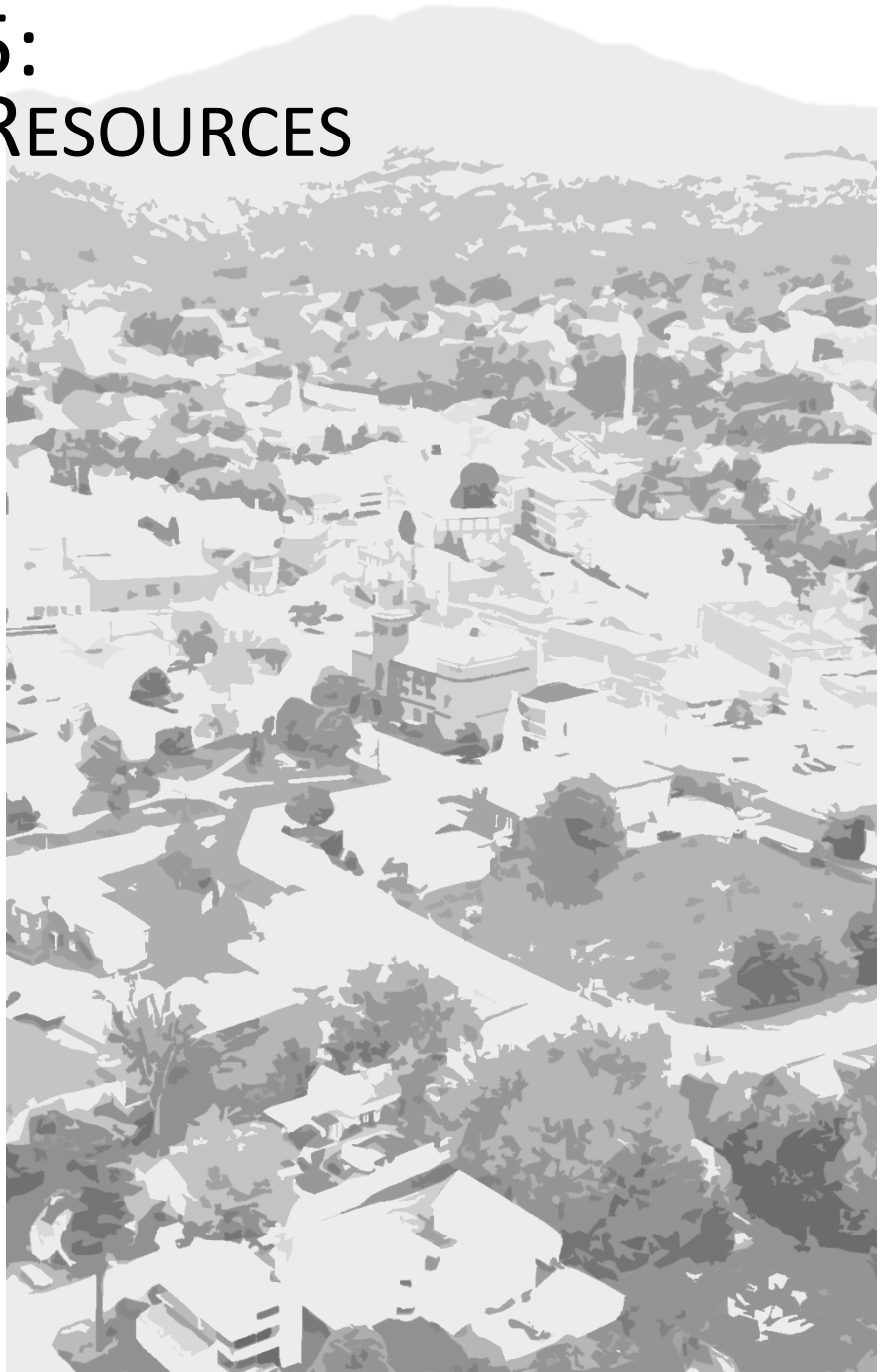


CITY OF CLAREMONT MASTER PLAN 2017

CHAPTER 5: HISTORIC RESOURCES

Prepared by the
Claremont Planning Board
and the
Claremont Planning and
Development Department



Chapter 5: Historic Resources

Vision

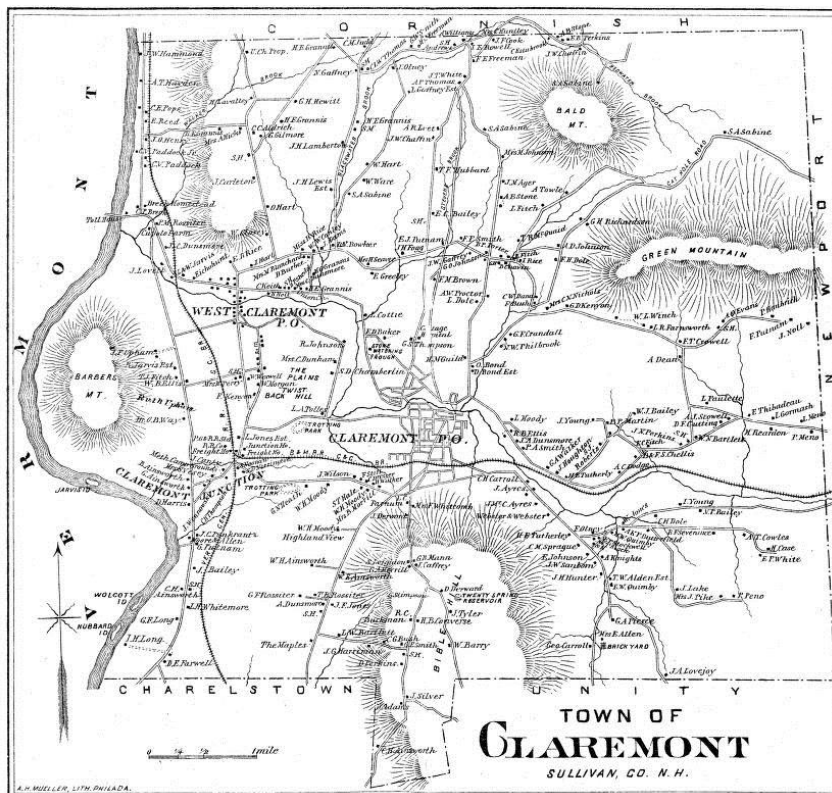
The City will continue to recognize the importance of preserving and protecting its historical resources for present and future generations. These resources are essential for the cultural and economic well-being of the City. They contribute to our “sense of place”, have substantial historic and architectural value, and are a source of pride in the community.

The architectural unity of the City Center creates a cohesive downtown that is unique in the state of New Hampshire. The City will strive to preserve and protect its wonderful historic resources through:

- Creativity in the adaptive re-use of its existing structures;
- education,
- public/private partnerships, and
- limited regulation.

Introduction

In this chapter, the term “historic resources” is taken to mean a district, site, building, structure or object that is significant in the history, architecture, engineering, archeology or culture of this community.



At a Master Plan Public Forum held in March of 2016, the 75 participants were asked several questions relating to historic preservation. 62.5% of respondents agreed that Claremont is well known for having outstanding architectural resources and that it is important to protect them. 80.33% of respondents agreed that the buildings in the City Center create a positive impression of Claremont, but only if they are well maintained and occupied. It is therefore acknowledged that Claremont’s historic resources are highly valued

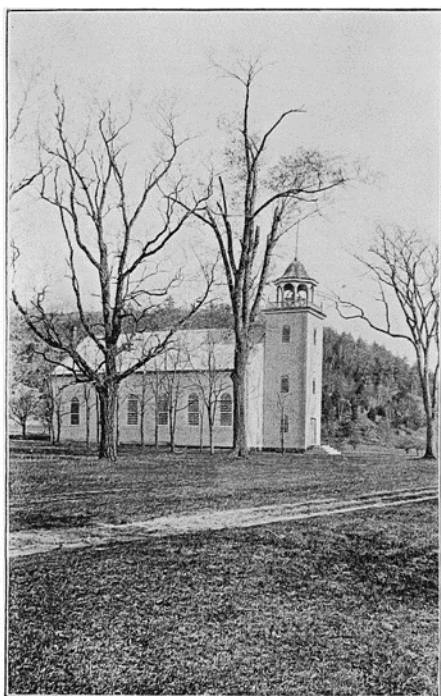
by the community and their preservation is important for a variety of reasons. However, it is also acknowledged that preservation for its own sake is of less value than the creative and adaptive re-use of those same resources. Finding new uses for historic structures that will generate income for their rehabilitation and future maintenance is highly desirable.

Forum attendants were almost evenly split on the question of extending the Historic District along Broad and Pleasant Streets to Summer Street.

Brief History of Claremont

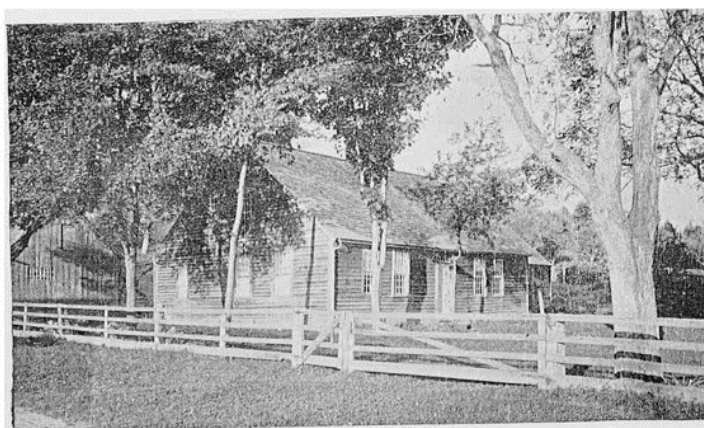
1764 – 1800

Claremont received its charter in 1764 and was originally divided among the proprietors into parcels of land used for common land, farming, and timbering. West Claremont with its fertile land was the center of this development. However, farms were also spread out along the banks of the Sugar River and the slopes of Green Mountain.



UNION CHURCH, WEST CLAREMONT.

The early center of town was in West Claremont where the Congregationalists and Episcopalians came together to build a shared church – Union Church. This union ended when the Congregationalists moved to the southern end of town and built their own meetinghouse off Maple Ave. The Episcopalians remained in the old settlement area completing their church after the Revolutionary War.



JOHN TYLER HOUSE, WEST CLAREMONT.

1800 – 1830 City Center

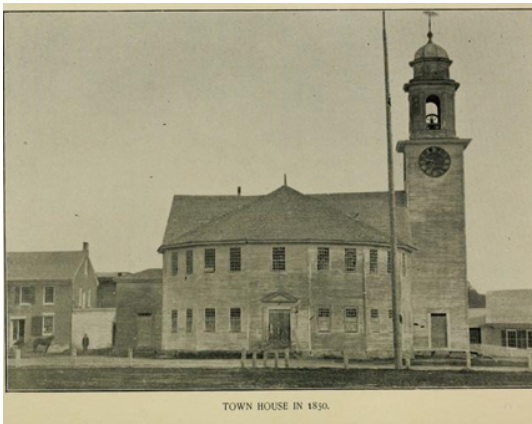
In the early 1790's the town acquired land on the Plain (Broad St.) for a more centrally located town hall. Ichabod Hitchcock, master carpenter, moved the Congregational Meetinghouse to the site of the present-day City Hall, thus securely establishing this area as the center of town. It was replaced with a new brick Town Hall and Opera House in 1897

The main street, centered on Broad Street with its town park, had a mixture of uses including the first bank, a small shoe factory and churches, but was primarily an area of fine homes built by some of Claremont's leading citizens.

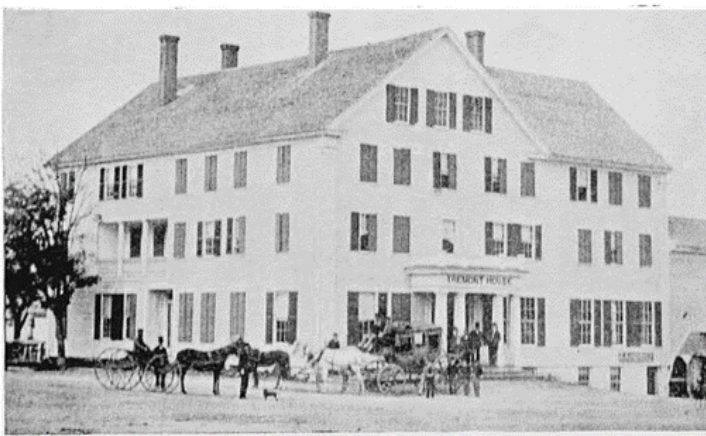
Tremont Square (now Opera House Square) was the center of commercial enterprises. The downtown developed with a mix of industrial, mercantile and residential uses.



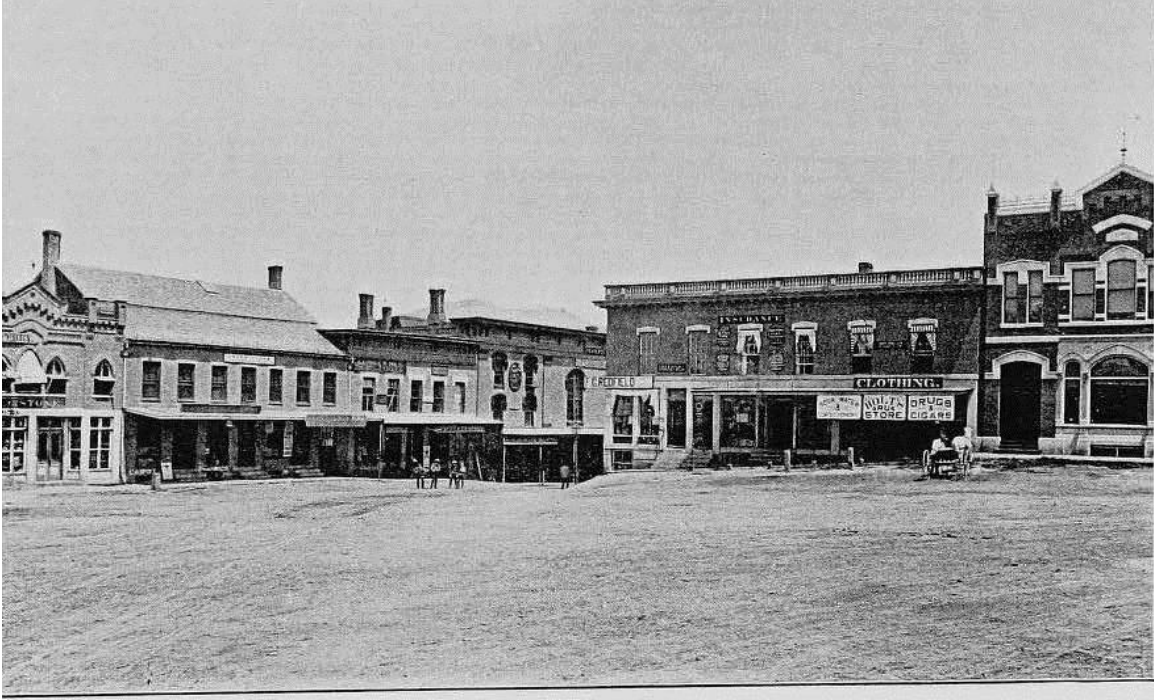
VIEW IN BROAD STREET.



TOWN HOUSE IN 1830.



TREMONT HOUSE IN 1870.



EAST SIDE OF TREMONT SQUARE.

1830 – 1930 Industrial Development

This period, starting in the 1830's, began the transformation of Claremont from a typical New England village to an industrial city due to the expanded use of water power along the Sugar River with sites for up to nine dams. Around the bridge on Main Street numerous industrial and commercial sites were developed over the next three decades, while both private and industrial housing lined Main Street to the east and west.



As the town continued to grow, due to the development of the mills in the late 19th century, the commercial center began to expand to Pleasant Street which had been primarily residential. Fine homes were eventually replaced with large commercial blocks all the way to the Congregational Church containing shops, professional offices, a hotel and Post office. Further commercial development on Pleasant Street continued past the church throughout the 20th century with less impressive buildings.



UNION BLOCK.



HIRA BECKWITH'S RESIDENCE.

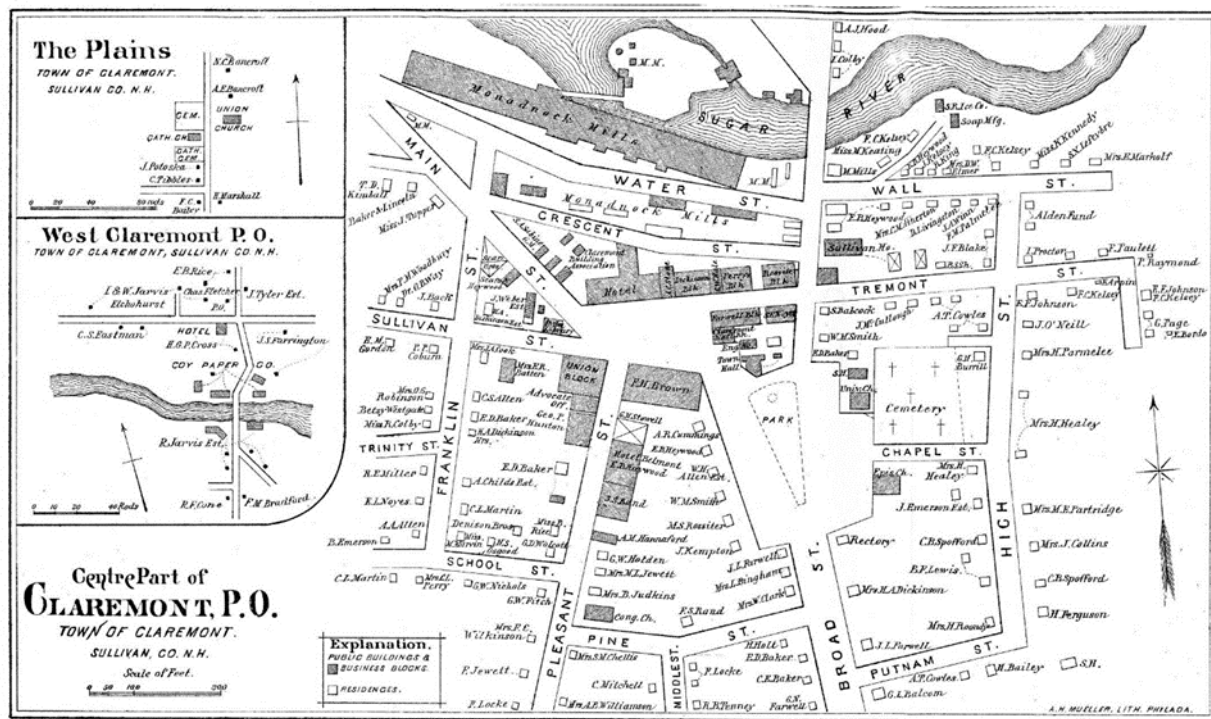
During this time, Claremont was fortunate to have the builder/architect, Hira Beckwith. His building design/style, primarily Queen Anne Style, was used for business blocks, civic, commercial, and factory buildings, and residential houses. It gave Claremont an architectural unity unknown to any other town in New Hampshire or Vermont during the Victorian Period.

Some wealthy citizens of the older town center, fearing that the town's center would shift to the rapidly developing Lower Village, formed The Upper Falls Company in 1836. This company evolved into the Monadnock Mills Company in 1843 and developed several specialized mill buildings mostly along Water and Crescent Streets for the production of cotton goods as well as housing for their workforce. Thus, began the development of

various mill enterprises on both sides of the Sugar River which continued to transform the town's center through the 1930's. Other than the Monadnock Mills, the most notable set of industrial buildings were erected by the Sullivan Machine Company, which later became Joy Manufacturing, a leading employer and dominant force in the community until it closed in the 1980's. Over time Joy built a vast array of buildings on both sides of the Sugar River as well as rail lines to transport their goods to markets.



RESIDENCE OF HON. HOSEA W. PARKER, CLAREMONT.





1930 – 1970 Urban Renewal

Joy eventually closed its facilities in the center of town and built new ones along 12A in West Claremont leaving a vast array of empty brick buildings in the city center. While some of these were converted to other uses over the years, many remained vacant. Time eventually took its toll on many of these structures due to a lack of maintenance and various fires. On the north side of the river, all but the Sullivan smoke stack were eventually torn down and now serve as a park, visitor center, and parking for the mill area. The establishment of the Historic District in 1978 allowed federal funding and tax incentives for some buildings on the south side of the river to be converted to residential use.

1970 – 2000

Of note during this period was the restoration of the Claremont Opera House, addition of the police station/atrium, and improvements to Opera House Square (then Tremont Square) and Pleasant Street. In the early 1970's talk of removing the upper floors of the City Hall/Opera House due to deterioration and safety issues spurred local residents to form a committee to put the building on the National Register of Historic Places and secure funding for its restoration. Federal funding was essential in securing most of the monies needed for these efforts. Beside the restoration of the Opera House, the Square was improved by a new parking area and gardens in the center, repaving the sidewalks with pavers, the burying of power lines and addition of historic lighting poles in the square as well as along Pleasant Street, returning the city center to a more appropriate historic appearance. The Opera House was re-opened in 1979 and again after full restoration in 1983. It remains a vital part of the cultural and economic vitality of the city to this time.



2000 – Present

In the first decade of the 21st century the City was finally successful in its attempts to develop a core of mill buildings along Water Street and Main Street. A complex public/private partnership was formed which converted two buildings into the Common Man Hotel & Restaurant, along with Red River Computer Company. Part of the old Sullivan foundry building was incorporated into a new parking garage and office space serving the mill complex. Unfortunately, a fourth building slated for high end housing was not completed due to the downturn of the economy and housing market in the second half of the decade. Despite the economic downturn, this development has set the stage for further positive development in the area once the economy recovers.



Current Status of Claremont's Historic Resources

The City's historic resources have been eroded over time by a variety of forces and at varying rates. For example, great destruction of historic property occurred as a part of an urban renewal project in the 1970's in the area between Washington, Broad, and Hanover Streets.

Several of the fine homes on Broad Street were demolished to create the current parking area opposite Broad Street Park. Others have been removed as the pressures of commercial development increased, most notably the area of the Claremont Savings Bank. Although some of the remaining homes are still used as residences, many have been converted to professional offices. A few of the fine older homes are still present on Pleasant Street, but have been converted to other uses. The architectural unity that defines the City center survived until the late 1960s when business sprawl and neglect began to take its toll.

In response to these losses, the Claremont Historic District Commission (HDC) was established in 1978. Tremont Square (now Opera House Square), Pleasant Street and Broad Street provided the business/residential mix in Claremont that was identified in the Historic District, the first multiple use Historic District on the National Register. Also of great importance within the Historic District was the development of the area from Opera House Square to the Lower Village.

The City center is still defined by its unique architectural unity, but its primary buildings are threatened. Several of the buildings on Pleasant Street are deteriorating from lack of maintenance and are underutilized because of ADA, building and fire code issues. Parking is often cited as a constraint to full utilization of these buildings as well. The ground floors of these buildings see rapid turnover in tenants and often present multiple empty storefronts, giving Pleasant Street an air of abandonment.



Many of the buildings in the Lower Village are suffering the same fate. The dilapidated appearance of some of them make them targets of vandalism and spark the desire to tear them down.

Future Challenges and Opportunities

Claremont's city center is one of its most valuable assets. Its architectural beauty draws visitors and businesses that benefit the city's economic health, and provides current residents with a strong sense of

place.

The challenge in protecting these valuable resources is in balancing the needs of modern society with the need to preserve our links with the past. It means finding suitable uses for historic buildings, locating funds with which to rehabilitate them in an historically sensitive manner, and encouraging private property owners to take the steps necessary to make their buildings economically viable once more.

The challenge in protecting the City's resources requires abundant outreach and education – educating the City about the value of its resources, educating regulators in the latest preservation tools and techniques and how to apply them, reaching out to private property owners and finding common ground between their needs and desires and the City's preservation goals.

On July 22, 2015, City Council adopted the provisions of RSA 79 – E, "Community Revitalization Tax Relief Incentive". The City recognized that there is a public benefit to encouraging the rehabilitation of underutilized structures in its City Center as a means of encouraging economic growth in a more compact manner and that tax relief can provide an incentive for such rehabilitation. Structures that qualify for the program are those that are located in the City's Downtown and Lower Village Historic Districts and those that are located outside the District that are listed or eligible for listing on the National Register of Historic Places. At the time of this writing, the rehabilitation of the Monadnock Boarding House at 13 Water Street is underway in part due to the provisions of RSA 79-E. Every effort should be made to ensure that all property owners within the District are aware of this program.



Many important buildings which help define the unique character of our community lie outside the area protected by the Historic District (e.g. the many fine homes and mansions along Charlestown Road.)

Religious buildings, schools, and barns are now becoming the next most vulnerable structures. Churches are seeing their memberships shrink to where they can no longer financially sustain the upkeep of their buildings; school populations are

shrinking and districts consolidate to save tax dollars; and farming is no longer the viable industry it once was. Yet the architecture of each of these groups of buildings is unique to itself and forms part of the visual tapestry that defines our heritage. Loss of them from the landscape will in turn alter the character of the community.

In addition, historic resources that are not actual buildings cannot be omitted from the list of historic resources to be protected. Features such as the Moody Estate Arch, the Tory Hole, Moody and Broad Street Parks and so on must not be overlooked. Loss of these resources would contribute to a loss of community identity.

There are also a variety of historic artifacts scattered throughout the City, including the eagle that once stood atop the original city hall; an antique air compressor from the Sullivan Machine Company; the bell atop the Unitarian Church, and the “gizmo” from the interior of the gas bell in the gas works plant (the only such “gizmo” remaining in the country). Each of these artifacts should be inventoried and made available for public viewing where feasible.

As witnessed by the recent mill re-development, historic structures can provide the defining character that many developers desire and seek. They help define the community and connect us to our past. By taking note of our history and taking advantage of some of the tools available, the city can manage both desired growth and preservation of the historic and cultural heritage that makes Claremont a unique and desirable place to live and do business.

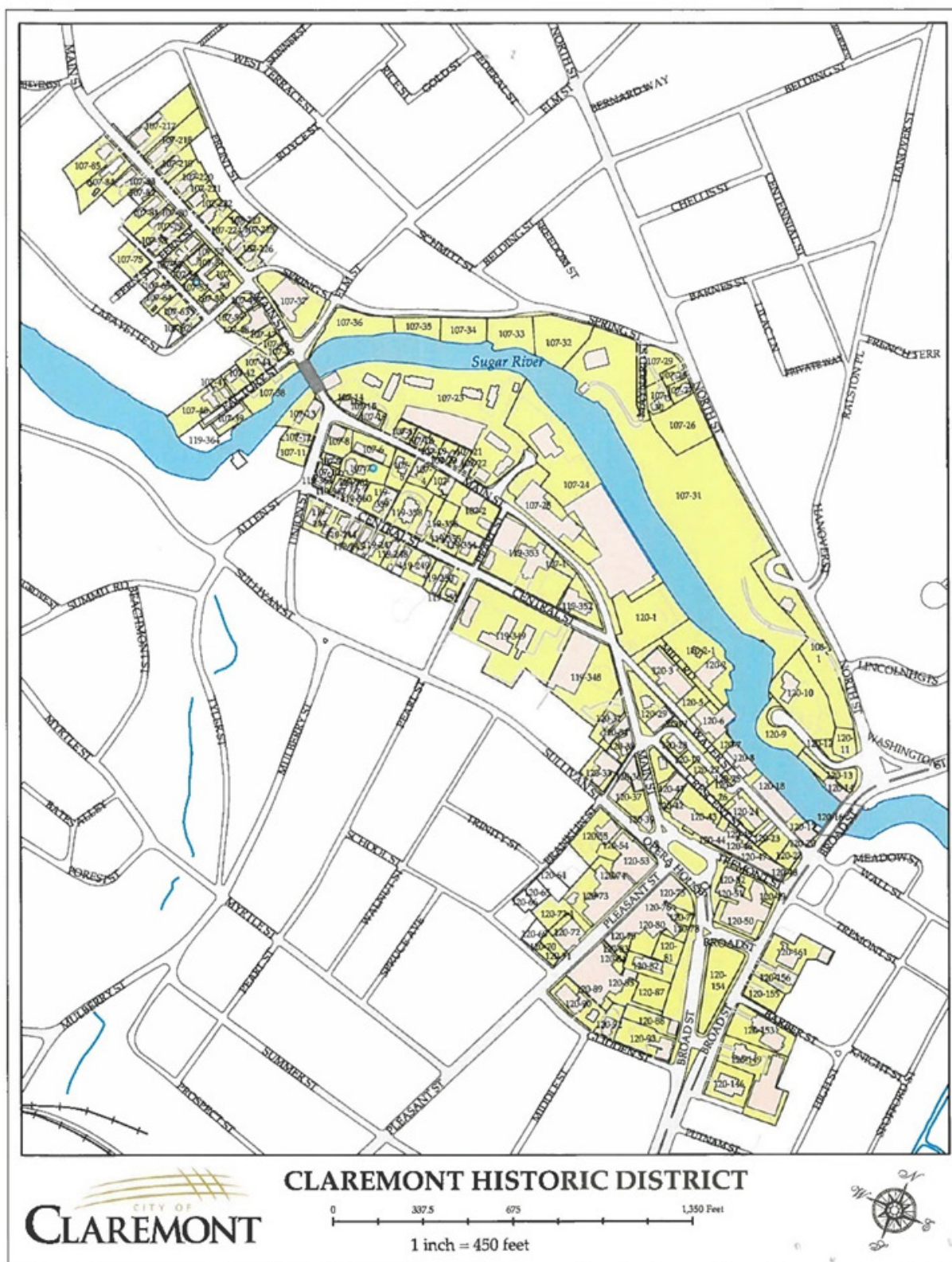
At present, the HDC is the only regulatory body in place to address historic preservation. However, its authority extends only to the exterior appearance of the buildings and only to those buildings that lie within the Historic District. (The HDC is also consulted when demolition of a structure in the historic district is proposed.) Additional tools, methods, and organizations will be required to preserve and protect the historic resources that lie outside of the Historic District and to engage in preservation beyond the exterior appearance of buildings.

Places in Claremont that are Listed on the National Register of Historic Places:

- Central Business District
- Hunter Archaeological site
- Lower Village District
- Monadnock Mills

Buildings in Claremont that are Listed on the National Register of Historic Resources:

- Claremont City Hall
- Claremont Warehouse #34
- David Dexter House (Lincoln Heights)
- English Church (Union Episcopal Church)
- William Rossiter House (11 Mulberry Street)



Goals

Preserving evidence of the past is one key to the future well-being of the community. Claremont's unique land use mix of an urban downtown with outlying farms and woodlands is in itself a reflection of the past. The mill buildings and farms are equally representative of Claremont's History. It is through creatively adapting the use of the City's historic resources that sustainable preservation will be achieved.

Goal 1. Preserve and protect the City's historic resources.

1. Continue to update and enhance the inventory of historic sites and structures so as to create a living document.
2. Determine which resources are most vulnerable to damage/destruction and create plans to protect them.
3. Implement the recommendations from the 2004 Historic District Assessment as appropriate.

Goal 2. Extend preservation/protection abilities outside of the Historic District

1. Continue to support the work of the HDC.
2. Explore the possibility of creating a Heritage Commission whose mission will be the long-term protection of the City's historic resources.

Goal 3. Expand preservation/protection tools beyond the exterior appearance of buildings

1. Become knowledgeable about the types of easements that may be employed to preserve or protect historic properties.
2. Use regulations and ordinances to preserve and protect.
3. Develop and implement zoning and site plan regulations that preserve and protect the historic character of Claremont and to ensure historic blending of new or rehabilitated buildings on the perimeter of the City.
4. Review the city of Claremont's zoning ordinance and the city's building and fire codes to identify regulations that would unintentionally impede the rehabilitation or reuse of historical properties
5. Review current zoning, subdivision, and City ordinances to determine current level of historic resource protection within the development review process.
6. Become knowledgeable about grant programs and how they might benefit historic preservation efforts.
7. Promote use of the federal tax credits in local historic rehabilitation projects.
8. Ensure that efforts are taken in subdivision applications to preserve historic farmsteads.

Goal 4. Seek to improve awareness of historic resources.

1. Secure funding for the City or Historical Society to print a Self-Guided Walking Tour booklet outlining the historical sites and buildings in Claremont.
2. Create a brochure that illustrates and defines the different architectural styles as a means of increasing people's knowledge about the City's historic buildings and structures.
3. Make the City's "Historic Sites and Structures Inventory" available to the public.

4. In accord with the mill history of Claremont, it would be appropriate, to designate space within one of the mill buildings, as they are developed, to provide a visual arts museum showing the town's waterfront development throughout the 18th and 19th centuries.
5. Create an inventory of the City's historic artifacts. Work toward making them accessible to the public where feasible.
6. Employ signage as a means of educating the public (local and tourist) about the City's historic resources.
7. Expand the historic landmark program by educating property owners as to the historic and aesthetic value of their properties, and by signing more properties.

Goal 5. Encourage adaptive re-use of historic buildings

1. Work with private property owners to encourage adaptive reuse of historic buildings while preserving the character- defining features of historic buildings and structures.
2. Prevent building demolition by encouraging the rehabilitation of historic buildings in ways that reflect and respect each building's historic character.
3. Ensure that future development is sensitive to the historic character of buildings and landscapes within the City
4. Encourage development that reflects and respects the historic landscape.



Appendices:

The following appendices have not been included in this printing. Digital copies are available online:

Appendix A: History

http://www.claremontnh.com/MP2017/HistoricResources_AppA.pdf

Appendix B: Historic Resource Inventory

http://www.claremontnh.com/MP2017/HistoricResources_AppB.pdf